

An aerial photograph of a tropical beach. The water is a vibrant turquoise color, transitioning to a deeper blue further out. The sand is bright white. Numerous colorful beach umbrellas in shades of blue, red, yellow, and green are scattered across the beach. Several small, thatched-roof huts are visible on the left side. The overall scene is bright and sunny.

DEI 616: MULTIMEDIA STORY PROJECT

Lost in Place

FIND YOUR STORY

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ADJUSTING THE SOLUTION

Experience culture from the inside.

The Oversights

- Sharing fictional encounters can tokenize the users we are trying to consider
- Places and environments were not yet active storytelling elements

The Update

A platform where real people share their own stories tied to the places they visit. The experience of encountering those stories teaches you about others, culture, and yourself.





The swaps.

Scripted scenes	→	User-contributed stories
Branching narratives	→	Location-based interface
Designed multimedia layers	→	User-generated media
Setting "backdrop"	→	Sensory & physical experience

UNDERSTANDING THE PROBLEM

Challenging what feels “normal”.

The Gap

Cultural exposure is filtered through tourism, media stereotypes, and surface-level facts, never from the inside.

The Cost

Unexamined misunderstanding quietly reinforces that one way of being in the world is the default.

The Opportunity

Storytelling that places you inside another person's world and allow you to learn about places by feeling what it's like to move through them from someone else's perspective.



THE UPDATED VISION

A platform where place and personal narratives collide.



Geo-located stories.

Users explore a map of contributed stories from travellers, locals, and everyone in between, tied to specific locations around the world.

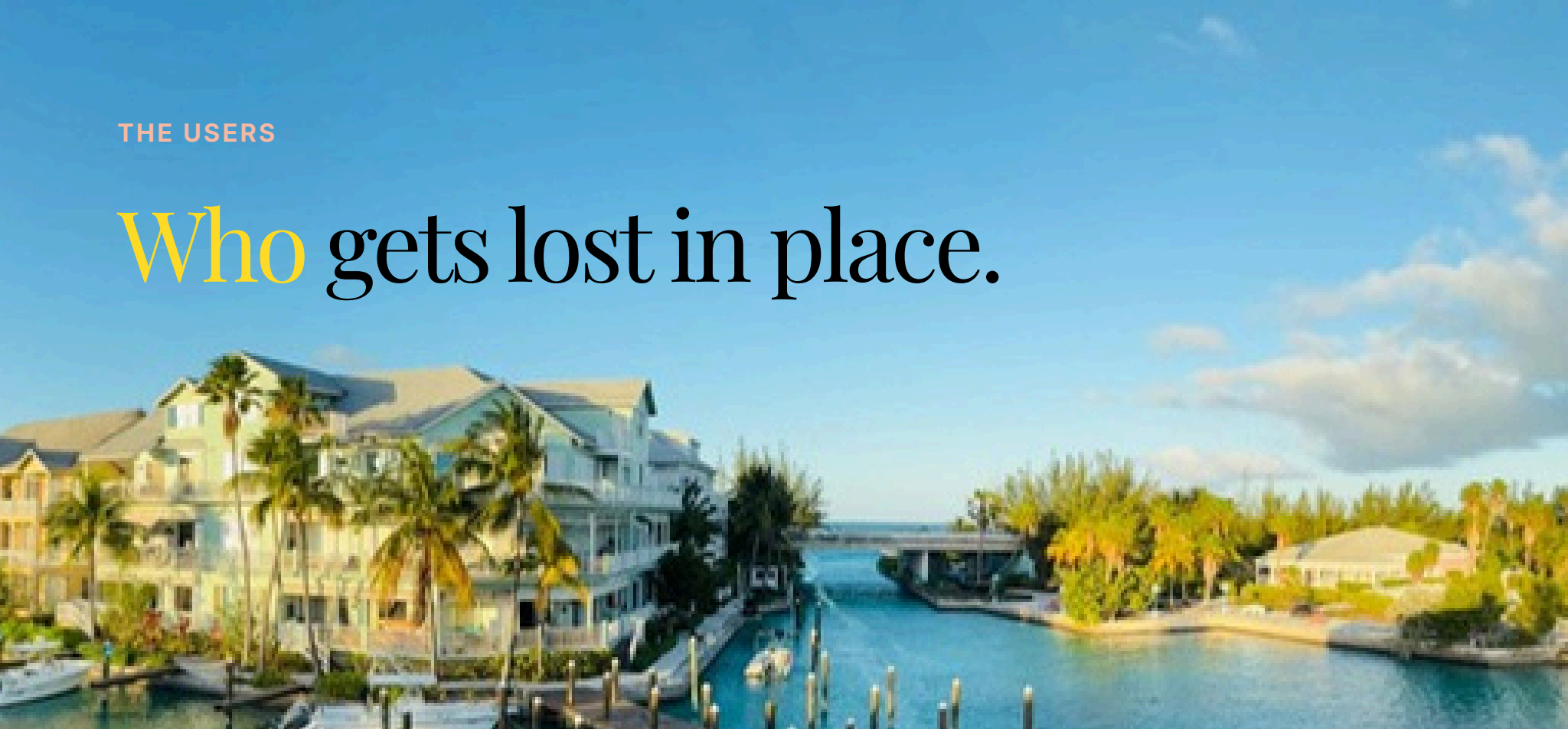
The untranslatable moment.

Contributors are invited to share moments that have no equivalent in their own culture. Things that surprised them, confused them, or moved them in ways they couldn't explain.

The body as part of the story.

Upload prompts ask contributors to include something sensory: what did it smell like, what did your body feel, what did you notice physically that you wouldn't have noticed at home.





THE USERS

Who gets lost in place.

The culturally curious adult

Drawn in by curiosity and the depth of real stories, travel isn't the motivation, it's about learning and exploration.

The first-time or nervous traveller

The platform acts as travel preparation and a way to get to know local culture before arriving.

The globally-minded professional

Cultural understanding is an ongoing practice and the platform fits into a life already shaped by cross-cultural relationships and environments.

STORY, INTERACTION, ACTION

The story is everywhere. The **interaction** is yours to choose.

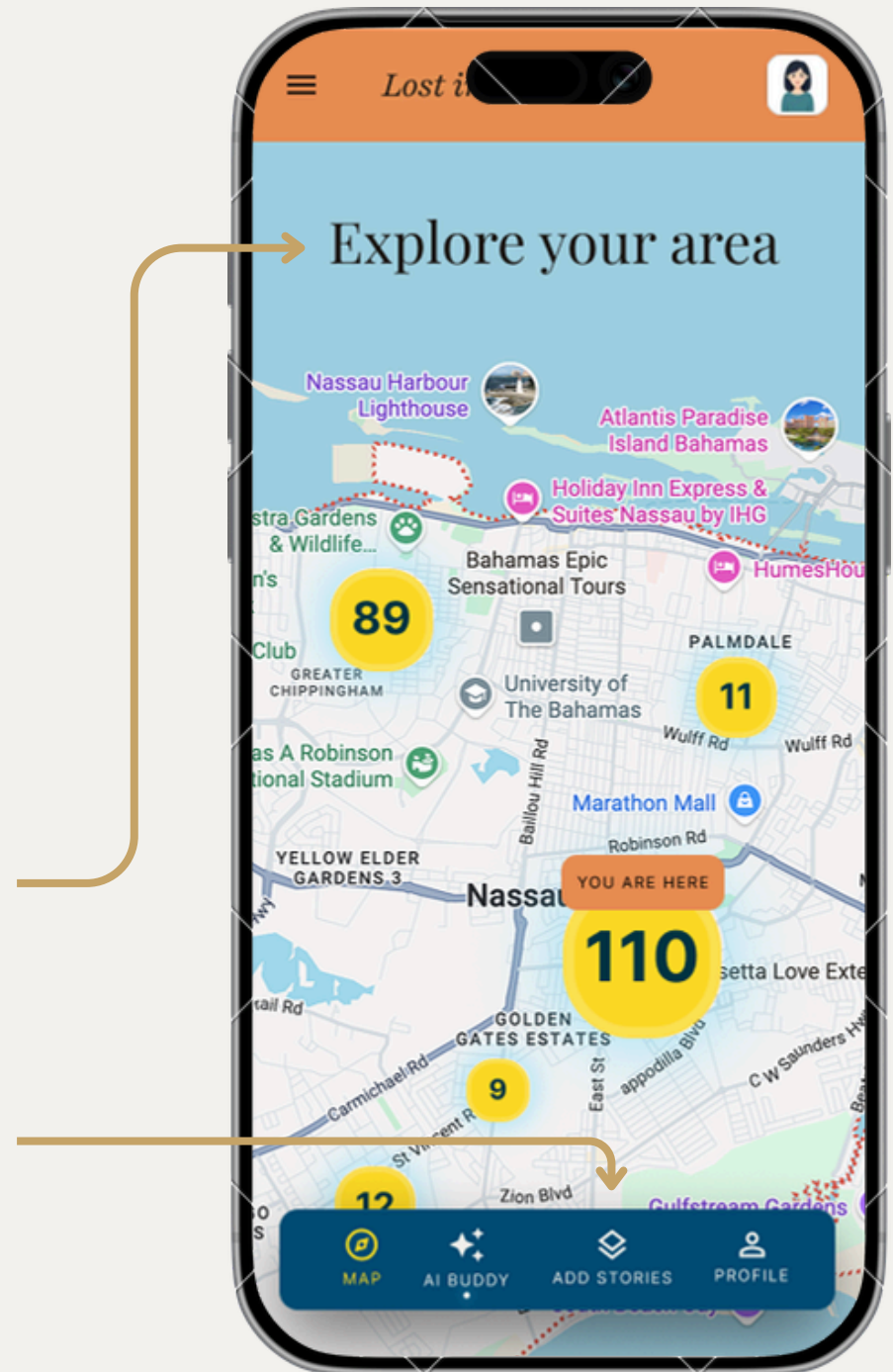
Two Primary Roles

Explorer:

- Browse geo-located feed
- Filter by medium, creator, traveller type, story category
- Build cultural fluency

Contributor:

- Upload stories in a variety of formats
- Stories are tagged to location
- Earn a local guide verification badge

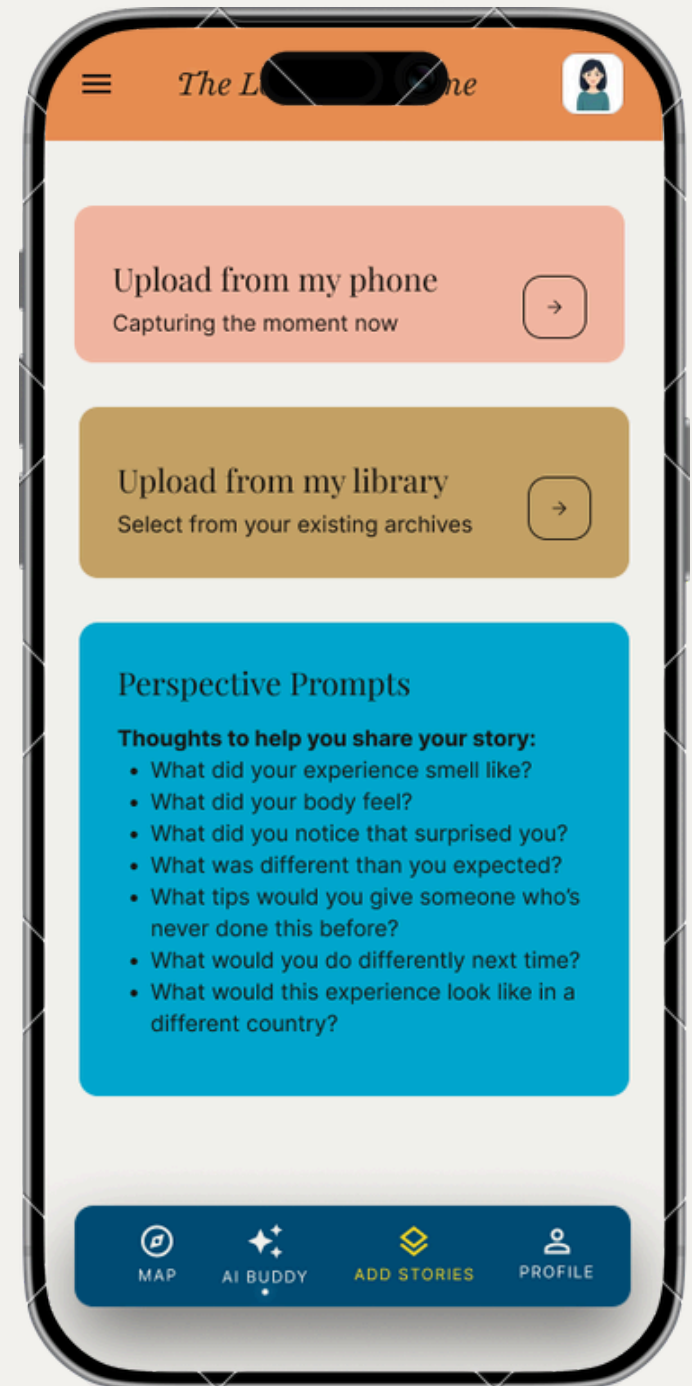


STORY, INTERACTION, ACTION

Every place has a story, and **we are all part of it.**

Stories surface from the exact spot told by someone completely different – different country, different body, different reason for being there – which creates layers of encountering people's experiences that would be otherwise missed.

The platform prompts contributors to share their perspective in meaningful ways.

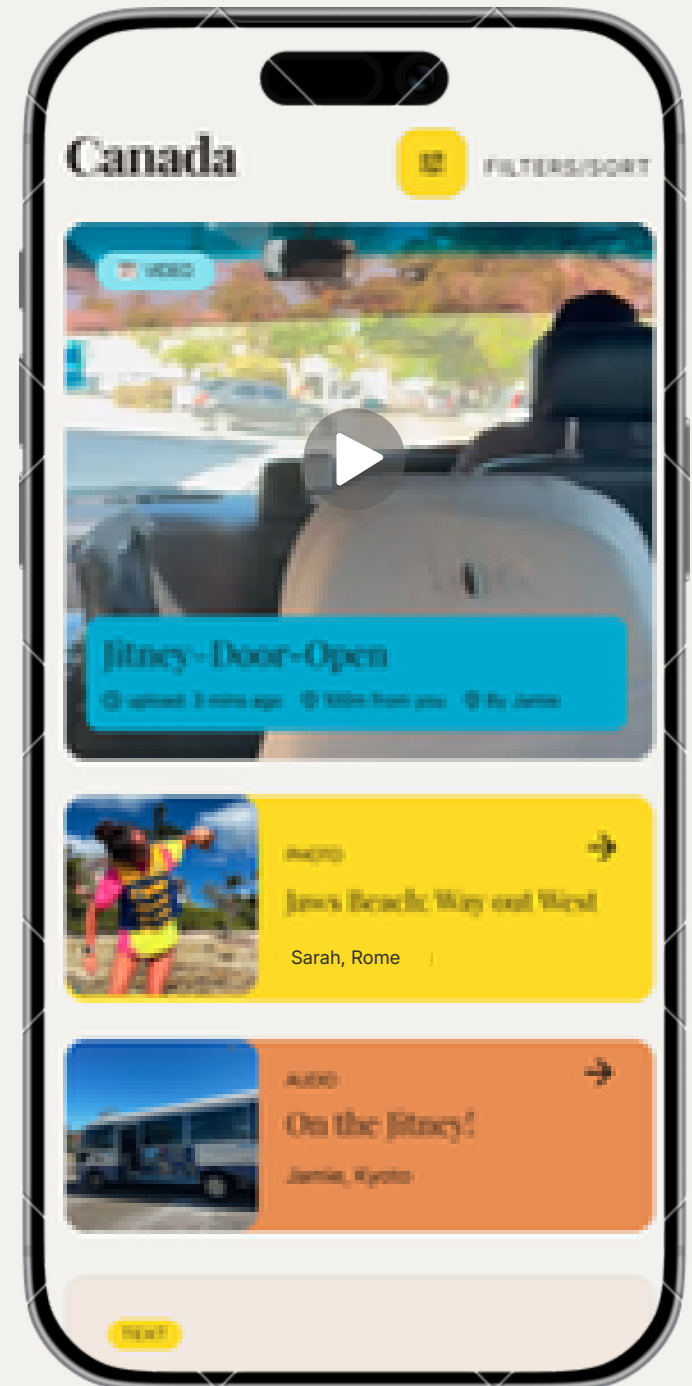


The platform allows **each medium** to speak in **its own way**.

Offering affordances to capture the story.

Support for four media formats:

1. **Video.** Captures movement, faces, and ambient life.
2. **Audio.** Shares voices, environments, and sounds that are difficult to translate.
3. **Photo.** Makes a fleeting moment stand still for all time.
4. **Text.** Carries thoughts behind a moment and additional context.



PLACES, ENVIRONMENTS, BODIES

The same place holds different stories depending on who's moved through it.

Stories surface from the exact spot told by someone completely different – different country, different body, different reason for being there.

This creates layers of encountering people's experiences that would be otherwise missed.



PLACES, ENVIRONMENTS, BODIES

Your cultural assumptions are the most interesting thing about you.

AI Buddy gently helps users surface the assumptions they bring to a place.

Quizzes are personalized to a user's country of origin to reveal their cultural lens and the expectations, instincts, and defaults they carry.



RISKS & LIMITATIONS

What we **can't fully solve** yet.

- **Content Moderation:** Framework to identify harmful, misleading, or exploitative stories.
- **Verification & Authenticity:** Process for verifying story and creator accuracy.
- **Crisis & Emergency Scenarios:** Framework for what happens when places are unsafe.
- **Cultural Sensitivity of AI Content:** Risks of generalization and stereotyping
- **Data Privacy:** Personal and place data carries legal and social risk.
- **Algorithmic Bias:** Recommendation systems carry bias and needs careful consideration.



Where we go from here.

- **Contributor Onboarding:** A guided early experience to help users navigate the platform.
- **AI Buddy Buildout:** Additional cultural context and personalization; navigation support.
- **Gamification:** Users earn a local fluency rating and a local guide badge verification.
- **Assumption Reveal:** AI Buddy surfaces expectation questions before/after watching a story.
- **Accessibility:** Screen reader compatibility, captions, adjustments for impairments.
- **Community Review:** Flagging and community review system for misrepresentation.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

What we **learned** along the way.

What immersive actually means

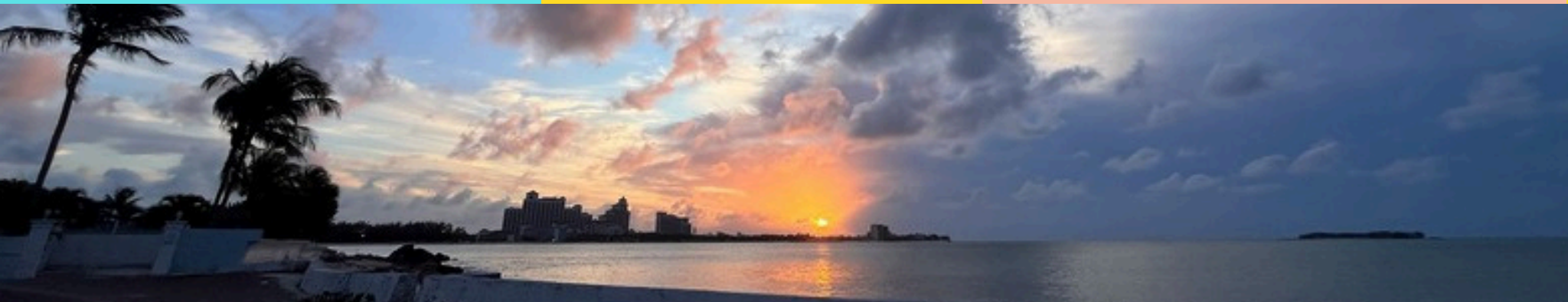
A screen-based branching narrative isn't immersion. Asking users to be physically present where a story was told gets close to an immersive experience and uses place in a more meaningful way.

Control vs. authenticity

Trusting people to tell their own stories produces a richer, ethical experience with the opportunity to grow beyond our initial vision.

The platform shift also shifted the user.

Our original format kept the cultural encounter at arm's length. A platform helps place users closer to the story, even if they aren't in the physical place it was told.



FIND YOUR STORY.

Co-creating
perspective.

Building collective
empathy.

Contributing to places
and stories.

Explore our prototype.

View our Figma file.

